How to Think About the Midterms

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On Tuesday, people across the United States will vote in **midterm elections**. These elections decide who controls **Congress**, the House of Representatives and the Senate, in the middle of a president's term.

A recent poll asked people about money. 44 percent said their finances have mostly stayed the same. 38 percent said things have gotten worse. Only 15 percent said things have gotten better.

History can help us guess what may happen. Since World War Two, the president's party has gained seats in the House only twice in a midterm election. On average, it loses 26 seats. When a president's **approval rating** is below 50 percent, the average loss is 35 seats.

Recent polls point to gains for Democrats. They are favored to win control of the House and are within reach of the Senate. Still, analysts say the size of any gain is not clear.

One reason is the map. There are about 30 fewer **competitive districts** than in 2018, and redrawing district lines helped Republicans by about eight seats.

Turnout could decide close races. Most races will be called on election night, but some may take days or weeks.

Word Treasure

midterm elections -- Elections held in the middle of a president's term.
Congress -- The group that makes laws for the United States.
approval rating -- How many people approve of how the president is doing.
competitive districts -- Districts where either party could win.
Turnout -- How many people vote in an election.

Background you need

In the United States, voters choose members of Congress in the middle of a president's term.

Congress makes laws for the country.

The party that wins more seats gains more power to pass its plans.

Break it down

WHO: Voters across the United States
WHAT: They will vote in midterm elections
WHERE: Across the United States
WHY: To decide who controls Congress in the middle of a president's term

Why it matters

Elections decide who makes the rules that affect your school, your town and your family.

Test what you remember

1. **What do the midterm elections decide?**
   - (A) The next president
   - (B) Who controls Congress
   - (C) District lines
   - (D) Money prices
2. **What share of people said their finances have mostly stayed the same?**
   - (A) 44 percent
   - (B) 50 percent
   - (C) 15 percent
   - (D) 38 percent
3. **Since World War Two, how many times has the president's party gained House seats in a midterm election?**
   - (A) 35 seats
   - (B) Twice
   - (C) 30 districts
   - (D) 26 seats
4. **Which party is favored to win control of the House?**
   - (A) Republicans
   - (B) Democrats
   - (C) Analysts
   - (D) Voters
5. **What is one reason the size of any gain is not clear?**
   - (A) Turnout
   - (B) The map
   - (C) Election night
   - (D) The poll
6. **When will most races be called?**
   - (A) On election night
   - (B) On Tuesday
   - (C) In 2018
   - (D) Days or weeks later

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: A 3: B 4: B 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Analysts: The size of any gain is not clear.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):